

UNDERSTANDING WRITING AND DEVELOPMENT OF WRITING SKILLS



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6.1 INTRODUCTION

In the preceding chapter, the focus was on developing an in-depth understanding of reading. This chapter extends that learning to writing, examining its nature, role, and significance in the classroom. We will understand the key issues related to writing and explore ways in which, as a teacher, we can create opportunities for practical and meaningful writing activities.



6.2 LEARNING OUTCOMES

After completion of this chapter, the learner:

- Understands the status and nature of writing pedagogy in our classrooms;
- Conceptualises writing as a composing and developmental process rather than a linear one;
- Provides opportunities for children to explore writing for authentic and meaningful purposes;



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- Designs learning environments that offer multiple opportunities to write for real purposes, helping children become independent and confident writers.

6.3 WRITING

Writing is a vital form of communication and self-expression. We share our feelings, opinions, concerns, thoughts, and ideas through writing. We write to communicate our ideas and emotions to others. Writing is a fundamental part of our lives as it allows us to share, express, and explore our emotions, feelings, and thoughts.

We use writing in our daily life for many purposes. Just think and consider for how many tasks we use writing in a day. You will find that we rely on writing for numerous tasks such as recording messages, taking notes, making lists, marking reminders, and more. The involvement of writing in our lives is integral.

6.3.1 Pedagogy of Writing in Primary Classrooms

Writing is very important in school. One goal of school is to help children learn to read and write well. That is why we focus heavily on writing in our classroom. If you look closely, you'll see children spend most of their time doing writing activities. They write across all subjects, regardless of their subject matter. We also use writing to assess children's understanding. Because of this, writing holds great importance in our school. However, we should also consider whether the kind of writing we are promoting is authentic and genuine writing.

In defining writing, terms like 'expression', 'communication', and 'connecting with the readers' are emphasised. However, in our schools, students are often introduced to a different version of writing. It is frequently taught as a skill of copying accurately from the blackboard with neat handwriting. Most of the writing tasks assigned to students are simply copying exercises. Students are expected to copy neatly in beautiful handwriting from the blackboard or help books. Moreover, writing is often equated with the skill of handwriting (Kunwar, 2013; 2015).

The opportunities for engagement with independent and authentic writing are almost negligible. Rarely, in schools, children are asked to write on topics related to their experiences, such as 'My Memorable Day', 'My Sibling', or 'What I want to change in my school'. Instead, students are asked to write only on



fixed routine topics such as ‘Independence Day’, ‘Deepawali’, or ‘Importance of Discipline’. Most of the time, students are expected to copy the content from guidebooks accurately in beautiful handwriting. Hence, the writing in schools is reduced to becoming mechanical, prescriptive, and limited.

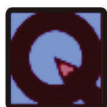
6.3.2 Teaching Writing to Children

Writing is communication. We write to share our perspective, views, thoughts, or opinions. For children as well, writing should hold the same meaning—it should be a tool for genuine expression and communication, not just a mechanical task. Children must engage with writing as a way to express their feelings or thoughts. It will be possible when children get opportunities to write about their personal lives and experiences.

Graves (1983) described Voice as the most essential factor in writing. He described voice as the core of writing. Graves further shared that voice will reflect in writing only when the child has the opportunity to write about their lives freely. By focusing on a few essential factors, we can give children a chance to write with voice:

- Give children topics related to their lives for writing.
- Provide regular time for independent writing in your class.
- Encourage children to make decisions related to their writing.
- Focus on the content of the child’s writing and not on grammatical errors.
- Provide responsive feedback on the writing of the child.

Writing should be a meaningful way for children to communicate their thoughts and experiences. By providing children with opportunities to write about topics related to their lives, establishing a regular writing time, allowing choice, and offering supportive feedback focused on content, a teacher can help children engage meaningfully with writing. Instead of emphasising routine grammar exercises, teachers should give children chances to write about meaningful topics.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 6.1

1. How is writing conceptualised in the primary years?
2. Why should teachers focus more on content than on grammatical errors when assessing children’s writing?



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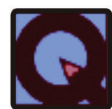
6.4 WRITING AS A COMPOSING PROCESS

In our classrooms, writing is mainly seen as a finished product. Teachers often write on the board and ask students to copy it carefully. Also, too much importance is given to neat handwriting and the appearance of the work. Hence, in the name of writing, only the work presented in notebooks is focused.

Many scholars across the world claim that writing should be seen as a process. To create a piece of writing, a writer goes through different steps. Each step helps to improve the writing. Various researchers have named these steps in different ways. Graves (1983), for example, said the steps are pre-writing, writing, and post-writing. Flower and Hayes (1981) described the process as planning, translating, and reviewing. Tompkins (2004) listed the steps as pre-writing, drafting, revising, editing, and sharing. According to Tompkins, writing is a repeating cycle of these steps. All these steps are explained briefly below:

- 1. Pre-writing:** This is the most essential part of writing. It includes choosing a topic, gathering information, and deciding on the structure, style, and audience. Good writing starts with enough time spent on this initial step because it is the basic foundation.
- 2. Drafting:** In this stage, the writer puts ideas on paper. All ideas from the pre-writing stage are arranged into a first draft. The writer can write, rewrite, and improve the draft through multiple versions. This process allows the writer to shape the writing according to their thoughts. By the end of this stage, a final draft is ready to move on to the next steps.
- 3. Revising:** The writer shares the final draft with the audience to get their feedback. Based on their suggestions, the writer can make changes like adding, deleting, or reorganising parts of the writing.
- 4. Editing:** In this stage, the writer focuses on correcting spelling and other mechanics of his/her compositions. By using a dictionary and other tools, the writer edits his/her work to make it grammatically correct. It is important to note that correction of mechanics is only done later in this stage. At the beginning of writing, the writer only concentrates on the content, and only at the later stage does the attention to mechanics come into play.
- 5. Publishing:** In this stage, the writer publishes his/her writing and shares it with his/her prospective audience.

To sum up, viewing writing as a process of composition highlights the



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 6.2

1. What is the difference between writing as a product and writing as a process?
2. Write a short note on writing as a composing process.

6.5 WRITING AS A DEVELOPMENT PROCESS

Research scholars agree that young children are active creators of meaning. Children who grow up in environments rich in reading and writing have many chances to learn about writing skills. They do not need formal lessons to begin to understand how writing works. Instead, children learn by paying close attention to print around them. For example, they notice how parents make shopping lists, mark dates, write messages, and read books or magazines at home. Outside, they see print on ads, labels, billboards, and more. These observations help children understand why writing is critical and how it functions. Over time, children begin to explore writing themselves, often with paper and pencil, drawing, or making marks on walls, even before starting school (Graves, 1983).

Writing in children develops through a range of milestones, such as drawings, scribbles, strings of letters (often without space), and invented spellings (like ‘frnd’ for ‘friend’).

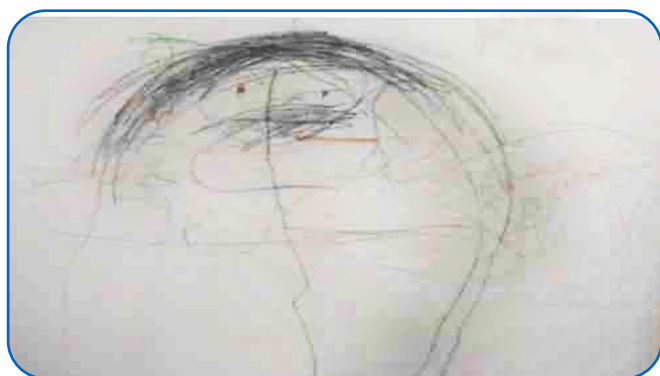


Fig. 6.1: Drawing as Emergent Writing
(The child has drawn the image of Lord Krishna with Bansuri)



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Fig. 6.2: Scribbling as Emergent Writing
(The child has written about waves he saw in the sea)

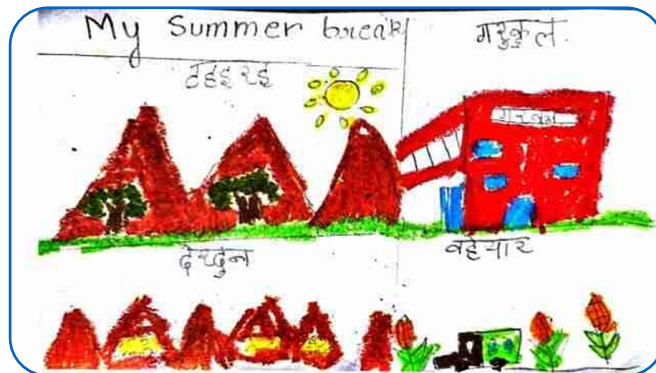


Fig. 6.3: Invented Spellings
(The child has written words related to her trip.
Words are Tehri, Gurukul, Dehradun)

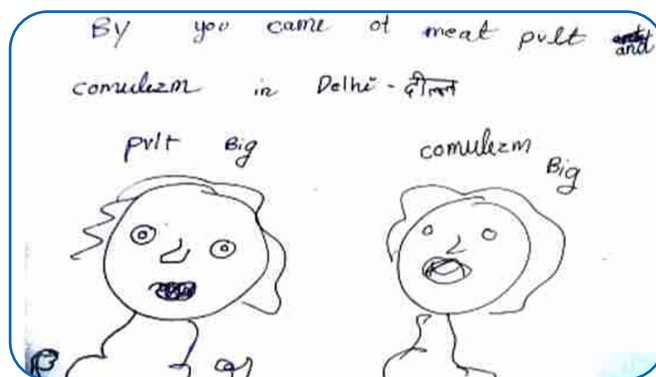


Fig. 6.4: Invented Spellings as Emergent Writing
(The child has written- WHY YOU COME TO MEET
POVERTY AND COMMUNALIZATION IN DELHI)

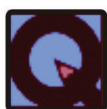
These initial types of writing are key milestones in the development towards standard writing, reflecting the child's increasing understanding of language,



purposeful participation, and writing objectives. It is essential to recognise that all children's writing holds personal meaning; these are not simply random marks, but each one conveys a message. Over time, with more exposure to print and meaningful writing opportunities, children's writing grows more conventional and organised.

In other words, young children progress through key milestones such as drawing, scribbling, and invented spellings during their writing development. These milestones reflect a child's ongoing growth in writing skills. Research by Ferreiro and Teberosky (1982), Harste, Woodward, and Burke (1994), and Teale & Sulzby (1986) indicates that drawing, scribbling, and invented spellings are vital stages in children's writing development. Such efforts should be acknowledged and supported. Additionally, Indian policy documents like NIPUN Bharat and NCF-FS recognise writing as a developmental process that develops alongside a child's cognitive, language, and motor skills. Writing starts with early mark-making, drawing, and scribbling, which serve as meaningful modes of expression for young learners.

So far, we have discussed writing as a composing process and as a developmental process. Remember that writing is not a one-time task; it is a process. Now, we will explore activities you can include in your classroom to give students authentic writing opportunities.



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 6.3

1. State whether you agree or disagree with the following views about writing.
 - i. Writing should begin only after children have mastered reading.
 - ii. Writing in the foundational years should focus primarily on correct spelling and grammar.
 - iii. Children develop writing skills through opportunities to express their thoughts and experiences.
 - iv. Writing is a process that includes thinking, drafting, revising, and expressing.
2. Justify the following statement.

“Drawing and scribbling are legitimate forms of written expression in the early years and support writing development.”



6.6 READING-WRITING CONNECTION

Reading and Writing are closely interrelated components. Good reading can make a good writer, and good writing can make a good reader. Reading and writing both support and nurture each other.

Teachers aim to support students in developing into confident writers. Therefore, it is essential that, alongside writing, students are also given good reading opportunities. Our literacy pedagogy must recognise the importance of connecting reading and writing. Teachers should strive to create activities that strengthen the integration of reading and writing. Establishing a connection between reading and writing can help students develop their

- vocabulary
- knowledge of syntax (sentence structure)
- knowledge of semantics (meaning of sentence)
- knowledge of pragmatics

There are multiple ways of strengthening the Reading-Writing Connection in classrooms. Some of the ways are suggested below:

- **Creating a Print-rich environment:** A print-rich environment means surrounding children with meaningful, engaging, and accessible print materials like books, charts, labels, story cards, posters, and children's writing. Having a print-rich setting is crucial for fostering joyful reading, improving vocabulary, and strengthening the connection between reading and writing. This constant exposure helps children become familiar with the forms and functions of written language. It makes reading and writing a natural and enjoyable part of their daily lives.
- **Provision of Class library:** A class library is a vital part of a print-rich and language-rich environment in early childhood classrooms. It refers to a dedicated area within the school that contains a wide range of age-appropriate and engaging books, including storybooks, picture books, rhymes, poems, folk tales, informational texts, and multilingual materials. Children see this space as a place of enjoyment and curiosity, not pressure. The goal of a class library is to promote reading and develop a love for books from an early age. It also helps to build the reading-writing connection by offering students regular chances to engage with rich and meaningful texts. As they observe characters expressing feelings and ideas in books, students begin to believe that their thoughts and words can also be shared in writing.

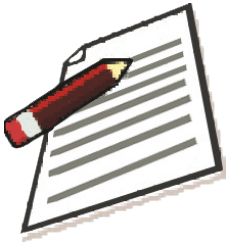


Fig. 6.5: Class Library and Children's Literature in a Primary Classroom

- **Access to Children's Literature:** Children's literature sparks imagination and fosters an emotional connection with written language. As children engage with meaningful and enjoyable texts, they start to value literature and respond thoughtfully. Reading such texts encourages them to share their ideas through writing. By seeing how feelings and thoughts are expressed in words, young readers naturally begin to link reading with their own writing experiences.
- **Creating Reading and Writing Corner:** These corners help create a print-rich environment where children are naturally surrounded by books and writing materials, promoting early literacy skills. They encourage independent exploration and motivate children to engage with texts and express themselves through drawing, scribbling, and writing at their own pace. These corners also strengthen the connection between reading and writing, as children begin to understand how thoughts and ideas can be communicated through written language. Such corners make learning joyful, inclusive, and meaningful.



Fig. 6.6: Reading – Writing Corner

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- **Language Experience Approach (LEA):** It is based on the idea that children learn most effectively when language learning connects to their personal experiences, oral language, and real-life situations. The NCF-FS also highlights that spoken language forms the foundation for reading and writing, and the Language Experience Approach follows this idea by turning a child's spoken words into written text. In this method, the teacher listens to a child's spoken account of a personal or shared experience (like a visit, activity, or story), and then writes it down exactly as the child says it. This written version is then used for shared reading, discussing words and sounds, and eventually helping children try their writing. This process allows the child to see their language in written form, helping them connect oral language with print in a meaningful and enjoyable way.
- **Response Journal:** Response journal is a personal writing tool where learners regularly write their thoughts, feelings, reflections, and responses to texts, experiences, or classroom activities. Response journals provide a safe space for young learners to practice writing in their own words. Children's daily experiences, whether from the classroom or the outside world, should be considered essential opportunities for writing. A portion of classroom time should be devoted regularly to sharing and writing about today's or/previous day's experiences in response journals. It is an effective tool to develop writing among young learners by making writing purposeful, reflective, and engaging, and reading as children read and share their responses with a chosen audience.

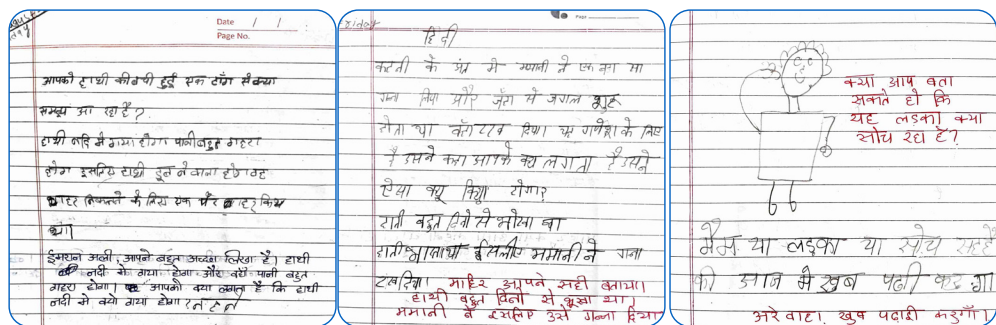
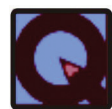


Fig. 6.7: Samples of Response Journal

In summary, reading and writing grow hand in hand through meaningful, experience-centred activities. A print-rich environment, access to a class library, and exposure to children's literature immerse learners in language and stimulate expression. LEA links oral language to writing by transforming children's spoken experiences into written form. Response journals enable



CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 6.4

1. What role does a print-rich environment play in the development of writing?
2. In an LEA activity, what is the role of the teacher?

6.7 INSTRUCTIONAL STRATEGIES FOR TEACHING WRITING

In this section, we will discuss some instructional strategies that can be used in classrooms for teaching writing to children.

6.7.1 Modelled Writing

‘Modelled writing’ refers to a teaching strategy where the teacher demonstrates the writing process to students by thinking aloud. The aim is to show students explicitly how to construct a text. The teacher shows a step-by-step process to indicate how she is composing the text, making decisions, and shaping her writing compositions.

The following example of modelled writing illustrates a teacher modelling the topic “My Most Memorable Day” and demonstrating the writing process step by step:

- **Selection of memorable day:** The teacher thinks aloud about which day she/he has selected as the most memorable.
- **Collecting and arranging relevant points:** The teacher verbalises and writes how she/he is choosing events that made that day special. He/She carefully arranges his/her ideas on the board, explaining to students how and why she/he is using a specific arrangement.
- **Developing paragraph-wise composition:** The teacher then demonstrates how she/he is composing her/his paragraph based on the gathered ideas. The teacher shows how he/she begins, writes the middle part, and concludes his/her composition.

Modelled Writing is a highly effective teaching technique for writing. This strategy allows the teacher to explicitly demonstrate the writing process by modelling how to generate ideas, organise them logically, and create a meaningful



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composition, thereby supporting children's early writing development through guided practice.

6.7.2 Shared Writing

Shared writing is an instructional strategy where the teacher and student work together to develop their writing. Based on a topic they both choose, they brainstorm and compose the text collaboratively. The teacher mainly acts as a scribe, demonstrating how to note ideas into sentences and add details. The main goal of shared writing is to show the thinking and decision-making that goes into writing. The teacher shows how to organise ideas, select vocabulary, and use proper mechanics.

An example of shared writing is given below:

A class decides to complain about the poor condition of their class almirah by writing a letter to the Principal. Both the teacher and students collaborate to develop this letter through shared writing.

1. **Establish purpose:** Writing a formal letter to the Principal to share a concern about the poor condition of a class almirah.
2. **Brainstorm ideas:** Ask students to think about all the points they should share in the letter.
3. **Writing:** The teacher shares the format of a formal letter, how one should start with greetings such as 'Respected Madam' and end with closing lines such as 'Yours sincerely'. Then, the teacher and students decide the main content of the letter. They determine how they can write about their concern clearly and politely. The teacher often gives signals such as 'How should we start?', 'What should we say in the beginning?', 'What should we say next?' and so on.

Shared writing is an effective instructional strategy because it allows both the teacher and students to experience the process of composing together. The teacher can easily demonstrate how to present ideas properly in writing. Additionally, teachers can clearly show writing conventions to students.

6.7.3 Guided Writing

Guided writing is an instructional strategy that provides focused and organised support at each phase of the writing process—before, during, and after



writing—to help students gradually develop independence and confidence in their writing abilities. Guided writing is particularly beneficial for students who need extra help with organising ideas, sequencing thoughts, and creating coherent compositions. It is typically done in small groups with children who face similar learning challenges. The steps of Guided Writing is provided below:

- 1. Establishes the objective of writing:** The teacher discusses the aim of writing with students, and, for example, writing about how they spent their summer vacations.
- 2. Plans the structure of the composition:** The teacher makes specific columns for the beginning, end, and middle of the composition.
- 3. Models writing:** The teacher shows students how she is planning her composition in the beginning, the middle, and the end.
- 4. Encourages students:** The teacher encourages students to attempt writing in the same way, following her style for each section.
- 5. Revising writing:** The Teacher foresees how the student has developed their composition and provides feedback.

Guided Writing is an effective strategy because it provides step-by-step support from a teacher. Since it is done with a small group, teachers get better space and time to interact with students with similar writing needs.

6.7.4 Independent Writing

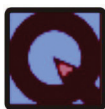
Independent writing is the stage when learners start writing independently, using oral language skills, vocabulary, and writing strategies they have learned through guided and shared writing experiences. This process should not be rushed or forced but should develop naturally and confidently once students have plenty of exposure to reading, oral language, and engaging writing opportunities. During this stage, students are encouraged to write for genuine and meaningful reasons, such as creating stories, journals, letters, reports, or reflections, based on their interests and real-life experiences.

Independent writing should be learner-led, creative, and minimally corrected in early stages. Teachers need to foster a supportive, non-judgmental space where children feel safe to explore language and learn from mistakes. Writing activities should suit developmental levels, offer choices, and be connected to other subjects to support practical and expressive writing. Through independent writing, students gain voice, agency, and ownership of their ideas, learning to

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communicate clearly and purposefully. Students should select their own topics and formats—this choice fosters a sense of control and boosts confidence in their language use. Educators should appreciate all writing efforts and refrain from excessive correction.

**CHECK YOUR PROGRESS 6.5**

1. What are the various ways of supporting the development of writing in the primary years?
2. Suggest three purposeful activities that can support writing in grade 3.

**6.8 LET US SUM UP**

In this chapter, we learned about a key literacy skill-writing. In various policy documents like NIPUN BHARAT, NCF-FS, and NCF-SE, writing is described as an emerging and developmental process that gradually unfolds through meaningful engagement with language. Regarding the primary years of schooling, NCF-SE views writing as a holistic, developmental, and communicative process that develops over time through active engagement with language. Instead of seeing writing as an isolated or mechanical skill, it should be connected with listening, speaking, and reading. We also learned how writing begins with drawing, scribbling, strings of letters, invented spellings, and slowly advances into more organised forms of expression. During the primary years, the focus should not be on copying or handwriting alone but on helping children express their ideas, emotions, and experiences through genuine writing.

We also learned that children write best when they are encouraged to express their thoughts freely, participate in real-life purposeful writing tasks, and see writing as a process supported at different stages — such as brainstorming, planning, drafting, revising, and sharing. A supportive classroom environment is essential for developing writing skills and fostering a love for it, where writing is meaningful, relevant, and connected to students' lives, experiences, and interests. Teachers are encouraged to use strategies like modelled writing, shared writing, guided writing, and independent writing, gradually increasing learners' interest, motivation, confidence, and competence in writing.



6.9 END EXERCISES

1. Reflect on your own school experience. How was writing taught to you? How is it different from how writing is conceptualised in the foundational and primary years today?
2. You are observing a grade 4 classroom. The teacher asks the children to copy answers from the board. Children are expected to write neatly but are not encouraged to express their own ideas in answers.
 - I. What approach to writing is being used here—process or product? What are the limitations of this approach?
 - II. Suggest alternative strategies the teacher can adopt to develop writing as a process.
3. Rani, a class 2 student, enjoys drawing and storytelling using her drawings but becomes anxious when asked to write in her notebook. She says, “I don’t know what to write.”

Suggest three ways the teacher can support Rani’s transition from oral expression to written expression.

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